

SNAKES

Snakes are predators with an elongated body and skin made up of overlapping scales. In a number of species modified teeth, or fangs, are used to deliver venom.

Although most numerous in tropical regions, snakes have adapted to live at colder latitudes and at altitude and are found on all continents except Antarctica. They are usually terrestrial with many living in trees, but some species burrow, some are semi-aquatic, and others live entirely in the sea. The smallest are tiny, thread-like creatures, but the largest can reach 10 m (33 ft) in length. Most are between 30 cm and 2 m (1–6½ ft).

A UNIQUE ARRAY OF SENSES

Some snakes have external vestiges of hind limbs, but they move by muscular contractions creating traction between the scales on their undersides and the surface beneath. A large number of flexibly linked vertebrae allows bending and coiling in any direction. The scaly skin is regularly shed to allow growth. Many snakes rely on just one elongated lung for breathing, while the gut is a simple tube with a

large, muscular stomach. Instead of eyelids that can be opened and closed, each eye is covered by a clear, protective scale. Eyesight can be good, but varies according to lifestyle. Lacking external ears, snakes detect sounds as vibrations from the ground as well as in the air. Their key sense is smell, not through the nostrils, but from airborne chemicals collected by the forked tongue. Some species can also detect the body heat of mammals and birds.

KILLING TO LIVE

All snakes are carnivorous. Their sharp teeth curve backwards to grasp and hold prey. Whether they eat their victim alive or kill it by injection of venom or by constriction, they consume their prey whole. Their uniquely elastic jaws allow them to swallow animals much larger than a snake's own head. Snakes defend themselves by camouflage, warning coloration, or mimicry. When threatened, they may strike out and bite.

Species in cold places tend to bear live offspring, whereas those in warmer climates lay eggs. Fertilization is internal. The male deposits sperm by means of one of his paired sexual organs, known as hemipenes.

PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	REPTILIA
ORDER	SQUAMATA
FAMILIES (SNAKES)	30
SPECIES	3,789



If threatened, the Mojave rattlesnake uses its characteristic rattle, bares its fangs, and coils up, ready to strike at the aggressor.

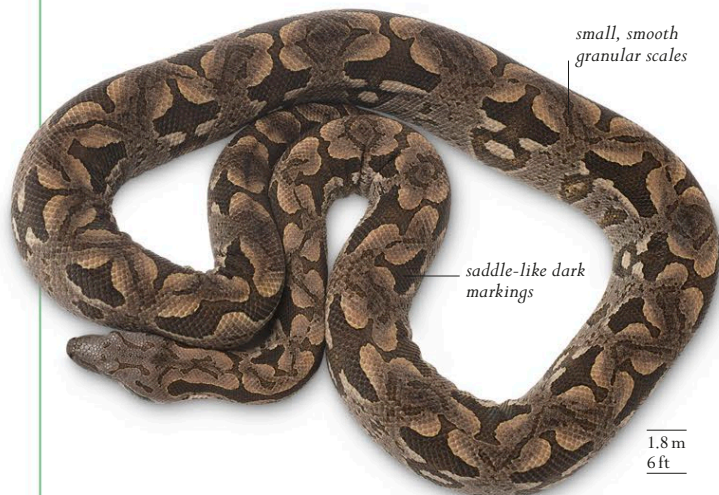
BOAS

The majority of Boidae are found in Central and South America, but a few species of boas are also present in Madagascar and New Guinea. These snakes are found from forests to marshes, where they prey on vertebrates, killing them by constriction. This family includes the anaconda, the largest living snake, and other species of varying sizes. Most give birth to live young.

DUMERIL'S BOA

Acrantophis dumerili

Found in the humid forests of Madagascar, this snake becomes torpid when sheltering in burrows during the dry, cool months.



saddle-like dark markings

1.8 m
6 ft

small, smooth granular scales



EMERALD TREE BOA

Corallus caninus

Found in rainforests of S. America, this arboreal snake preys on small mammals and sometimes birds. It has a slender body, long prehensile tail, and large head. The live young are brick-red or yellow-orange in colour, changing to emerald green at 12 months of age.

jaws dislocate to swallow large prey

white zigzag striping

1.5–2 m
5–6½ ft



1.5 m
5 ft

COMMON BOA

Boa constrictor

This large boa lives in a variety of habitats in C. and S. America. It is a nocturnal hunter of small mammals.

COOK'S TREE BOA

Corallus cookii

Endemic to St Vincent Island in the Caribbean, this rare snake hunts in trees for birds and mammals under the cover of darkness.